users' and of 'BJP infiltration'.[62] One report quoted a party general secretary as saying in an internal note that 'between 75-80% of *Shakti* registrations are bogus in each state … Crores of rupees have been sunk by the party in sending SMSes to mostly non-INC people. Consequently, the Congress has a huge database of fake workers with incorrect mobile numbers masquerading as INC workers.'[63]

An early variation of Shakti was tried in Karnataka in late 2017, before the May 2018 assembly elections in that state. Anonymous Congress insiders were later quoted in a report by *The Economic Times* (*ET*) as saying that fake data immediately became a problem. 'There was heavy pressure to collect data at the booth level, so 30%-40% of data had random names and random phone numbers,' said a Karnataka-based Congress functionary to *ET*. Karnataka has around 55,000 booths. So, if the Congress wanted eight–ten people per booth, 4–5 lakh members had to be found. As some insiders claimed, this effort was subverted by fake data.[64]

Incentivising data collection and linking preferential treatment to data volume created a special problem. 'District committee heads were catching every Tom, Dick and Harry, and were enrolling them,' a Karnataka Congress functionary told *ET*. At one stage, the party even held a competition, in which the prize for most enrolments was a meeting with Rahul Gandhi. The end result, party insiders say, was fake data of anywhere between 50 to 70 per cent across states. 'Only 30-35% were your normal karyakartas [workers].'[65]

The party's data head, who spearheaded the Shakti initiative, has denied these allegations. He emailed his colleagues on 23 May 2019, after the results: 'I have spent most of the day today wondering what we could have done differently, why we were not able to catch such a big trend with all the analysis and the surveys and so on. I have concluded there is not much we could have done. I think each of [sic] should be truly proud of your contribution and effort. We fought for a cause and while it may not have been fulfilled yet, we shall continue the fight until it is fulfilled.'[66]

Finally, the NaMo app is not just a messaging-dissemination platform for the BJP. It is also a built-in social network that works like